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Inside

•O.C.S. Student Exhibit
Impresses Engineers

PAGE 3

MODEL SEWAGE TREATMENT PLANT DISPLAYED

•500 Enjoy San Antonio
Festival

PAGE 5

FUN-FILLED AFTERNOON

•Castro Charges "C.I.A.
Complicity" In
Plane Bombing

PAGE 7

RENOUNCES ANTISKYJACKING AGREEMENT

•Zimbabwe Freedom Fighters
Seek Takeover

PAGE 17

Z.I.P.A. GUERRILLAS PLEDGE TO DESTROY
SMITH FORCES

Ericka Huggins Organizes First Community Meeting

BLACKS CONFRONT COUNTY BOARD OF EDUCATION

(Oakland, Calif.) — The Alameda County Board of Education held an unprecedented meeting last Thursday at Lockwood Elementary School here in the heart of East Oakland's predominantly Black community. During the three-hour and 15-minute meeting, some 150 community people — the majority of whom were attending a county Board of Education meeting for the first time — raised a number of key questions and criticisms related to the functioning of the Board and made concrete suggestions as to how the Board could become more accountable to the community it is elected to serve.

In addition, the community expressed its sincere desire to work with the Board in improving the quality of education in the public schools of the county, specifically as it relates to Black and other minority youth.

It was through the efforts of Oakland Community School Director Ericka Huggins that last week's meeting was held in East Oakland. Ericka, who was elected to the Board on July 1 as its first Black member, was instrumental in the Board's recent decision to rotate its monthly meetings in the seven trustee areas under the Board's jurisdiction. Ericka represents Trustee Area 6, which covers the Oakland flatlands.

Several community leaders and citizens expressed their appreciation that the county Board of Education had come to East Oakland. Paul Cobb, the Black Executive Director of Oakland Citizens' Committee for Urban Renewal (OCCUR), commented:

CONTINUED ON PAGE 6



As a result of efforts by Oakland Community School Director ERICKA HUGGINS (inset) the Alameda County Board of Education held its first meeting in East Oakland. Ms. Huggins was instrumental in the Board's recent decision to rotate its monthly meetings in the communities served by Board members.

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